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Research and evidence use in education policy: supranational discourses, systemic conditions and implications for decision-making communities

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Abstract

Purpose – This study investigates how supranational organisations conceptualise and strategically promote research engagement and evidence use in education policymaking. It examines the systemic conditions they advocate to support uptake and analyses how these conceptualisations are discursively constructed in policy texts. The paper also considers implications for decision-making communities, including policy teams, school leaders and professional networks, who interpret and enact these framings in practice.

Design/methodology/approach – The study employs interpretive policy analysis to examine how meanings, assumptions, and discursive devices are embedded in supranational policy texts. A curated set of six documents from the OECD, UNESCO and the World Bank (2020–2025) were analysed. Coding focused on rhetorical devices, metaphors, claims and systemic conditions, supported by inductive thematic analysis. This approach highlights how supranational discourses construct evidence cultures and configure systemic conditions for research engagement and evidence-informed policymaking.

Findings – Supranational organisations frame evidence as a strategic and symbolic resource, privileging certain epistemologies while marginalising others. These framings shape infrastructures and norms through which evidence is mobilised, influencing how decision-making communities engage with research. The analysis identifies tensions between instrumental and symbolic uses of evidence, highlights the role of metaphors in constructing evidence cultures, and shows how systemic conditions, such as governance traditions, institutional capacity and dissemination mechanisms, enable or constrain inclusive and reflexive engagement.

Originality/value – This paper advances interpretive policy analysis of supranational discourses, offering a conceptual framework that theorises how global framings configure systemic conditions for research engagement and evidence use. It contributes to debates on evidence cultures, epistemic inequality and symbolic versus instrumental use. The study provides insights into the discursive devices through which organisations coordinate evidence cultures and identifies implications for policy design, capacity-building and epistemic justice in education systems.

Keywords Education policy, Decision making, Education systems, Evidence use, Research engagement, Supranational organisations

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Introduction

The use of research and evidence in education policymaking is widely debated, with both terms contested in definition, application and legitimacy across political and institutional contexts. Supranational organisations such as the OECD, UNESCO and the World Bank shape these debates by promoting particular framings of what counts as valid evidence and by configuring the governance, capacity-building and dissemination infrastructures that determine how evidence is accessed, interpreted and used in national systems (Cairney, 2016; Pellegrini and Vivanet, 2021; Sellar and Lingard, 2014; Orland, 2009).

This paper explores how supranational organisations conceptualise and strategically promote evidence use in education policymaking, and what systemic conditions they advocate to support its uptake. It also examines how these conceptualisations are discursively constructed in policy texts, and what implications they hold for decision-making communities, such as policy teams, school leaders and professional networks, who engage with evidence in practice.

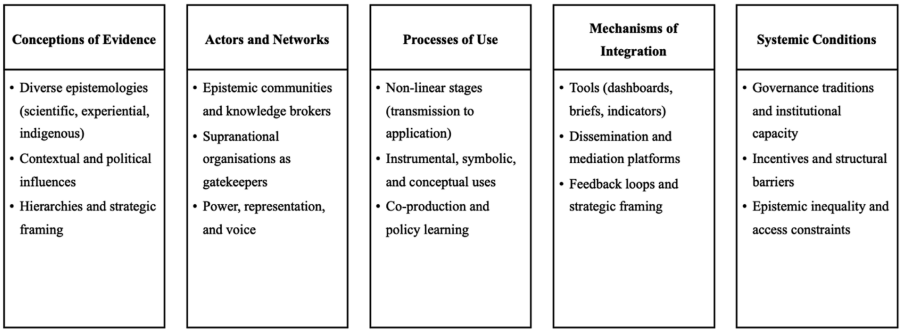
To address these aims, the paper is guided by two research questions:

(1) What conceptualisations and systemic conditions do supranational organisations promote regarding research engagement and evidence use in education policymaking?

(2) How are these conceptualisations discursively constructed and communicated in policy texts, and with what implications for decision-making communities?

Conceptual framework

Research engagement and evidence use in education policymaking are shaped by complex and changing interactions among actors, institutions and epistemologies. While evidence and research could be understood as neutral inputs, they can also be understood as being socially constructed and politically mediated, influenced by systemic conditions and strategic framings in policy and related discourse (Cairney, 2016; Lingard, 2013). Supranational organisations such as the OECD, UNESCO and the World Bank have become central actors in defining what counts as valid evidence and how it should be mobilised, often privileging quantitative methodologies while risking marginalising alternative epistemologies (Sellar and Lingard, 2014; Wadhwa *et al*., 2024). To analyse these dynamics, this paper draws on a conceptual framework comprising five interrelated domains based on related scholarship: conceptions of evidence, actors and networks, processes of use, mechanisms of integration and systemic conditions. These domains, represented in Figure 1, provide the analytic lens for interpreting supranational discourses and their implications for decision-making communities.



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Figure 1. Conceptualising research and evidence use in education policy making

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Conceptions of evidence

Evidence in education policymaking is conceptualised in varied and contested ways, shaped by epistemological, political and institutional contexts. Evidence is a dynamic construct influenced by purpose, audience and systemic conditions (Lingard, 2013; Cairney, 2016). In some cases, inclusive framings are adopted, recognising scientific, experiential, indigenous and practice-based knowledge as valid evidence. Burns (2023) distinguishes between information, knowledge and evidence, advocating for integrating diverse types to support systemic change. Pellegrini and Vivanet (2021) highlight the European preference for "evidence-informed" policymaking, more flexible and context-sensitive than rigid "evidence-based" models. Others, such as Cheung and Xie (2021), promote intervention-focused approaches privileging RCTs as the gold standard, while Wadhwa *et al*. (2024) critique this standardisation, revealing inconsistencies across clearinghouses. Strategic framings often position evidence as a political resource used symbolically to legitimise decisions (Orland, 2009; Bandola-Gill *et al*., 2024).

Actors and networks

Supranational organisations mobilise actor networks to disseminate evidence but also to shape the epistemic and institutional conditions under which it is legitimised and applied. Central to this are epistemic communities, understood as transnational groups of experts sharing normative and causal beliefs, who influence what counts as valid evidence and how it informs policy (Ball and Junemann, 2012; Leuze *et al*., 2008). Organisations like the OECD and UNESCO convene panels and advisory groups to guide policy development, reinforcing shared understandings and strategic framings intended to influence policy and related discourses (Verger, 2022; Fazekas and Burns, 2012). Institutional gatekeepers such as the OECD's Education Directorate, UNESCO's International Institute for Education Planning (IIEP) and the World Bank's Global Education Evidence Advisory Panel (GEEAP) curate evidence, set standards and frame narratives, often privileging particular epistemologies and forms of evidence and research use (Wadhwa *et al*., 2024; Burns, 2023). Brokerage organisations, such as the Education Endowment Foundation (EEF), Evidence for Policy and Practice Information Centre (EPPI) and What Works Clearinghouse, translate research into policy-relevant formats, shaping credibility and usability (Baek and Steiner-Khamsi, 2024). These networks span ministries, NGOs and research institutes, facilitating policy transfer and norm circulation (Bandola-Gill *et al*., 2024; Prøitz *et al*., 2023), but they also risk reinforcing exclusionary practices, particularly when Global South and indigenous knowledge is sidelined (Zhu *et al*., 2024).

Processes of use

The use of research and evidence in education policymaking is rarely linear. It instead unfolds through iterative, context-sensitive processes shaped by institutional norms, political agendas and relational dynamics (Lingard, 2013; Scanlon *et al*., 2023). Three primary modes of use are widely recognised: instrumental, symbolic and conceptual (Davies, 1999; Tseng, 2012). Instrumental use informs decisions directly; symbolic use legitimises pre-existing positions or signals credibility; conceptual use shapes understanding and frames problems over time. These modes often co-exist, reflecting strategic deployment instead of neutral application. Co-production and policy learning are increasingly emphasised as mechanisms for deeper engagement. Brown (2014) advocates for phronetic expertise developed through sustained interaction with research, while Court and Young (2003) highlight feedback loops and researcher–policymaker dialogue. Conditions such as time pressure, institutional capacity and political cycles influence not only the extent but the nature of evidence use. Post-COVID reforms, for instance, have intensified demand for research while also constraining deliberative engagement (Gunn and Mintrom, 2021; Burns, 2023).

Mechanisms of integration

Mechanisms of integration refer to the tools, infrastructures and practices through which evidence is mobilised, translated and embedded into policymaking processes. Supranational

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organisations have increasingly invested in developing these mechanisms to facilitate uptake across diverse education systems. Indicators, dashboards and policy briefs distil complex findings into accessible formats aligned with performance metrics and strategic priorities (OECD, 2022; Mileusnic, 2022). Dissemination platforms and mediation practices, such as UNESCO and World Bank repositories, curate and distribute evidence to policymakers and practitioners (De Vibe *et al*., 2002; Gorard *et al*., 2020). Strategic framing plays an important role in integration, with evidence constructed through narratives, exemplars and metaphors that align with policy goals (Burns, 2023; Ming and Goldenberg, 2021). Feedback loops, where evidence informs policy and policy generates new evidence needs, are increasingly recognised as essential for sustaining engagement.

Systemic conditions

Systemic and organisational conditions shape the possibilities and limitations of evidence use in education policymaking. Governance traditions play a foundational role where in centralised systems for example, the structure and norms may facilitate top-down dissemination and standardisation, while decentralised systems may allow for more iterative and participatory engagement (Wiseman, 2010; Fazekas and Burns, 2012). Institutional capacity, including analytical skills, infrastructure and leadership, determines whether evidence is interpreted and applied effectively (O'Connor, 2024; Lingard, 2013). Incentive structures and funding disparities further influence engagement, with underinvestment in educational research and development, and misaligned academic reward systems constraining potential uptake (Gunn and Mintrom, 2021; Scanlon *et al*., 2023). Structural barriers such as limited time, access to research and fragmented networks disproportionately affect practitioners and local actors, contributing to epistemic inequality and reinforcing hierarchies of knowledge. Supranational organisations increasingly recognise these constraints and advocate for systemic reforms that address capacity, coordination and equity, however tensions remain between normative aspirations and the complexity of practical realities.

These five domains highlight the complex and contested terrain of evidence use in education policymaking, showing how epistemological framings, actor networks, modes of use, integration mechanisms and systemic conditions interact to shape both the legitimacy and the uptake of research and evidence. They also reveal persistent tensions, such as between global and local knowledge, symbolic and instrumental uses and capacity and competency, that highlight the need for interpretive approaches attentive to discourse, power and context. Building on this conceptual foundation (Figure 1), the interpretive policy analysis that follows examines how these dynamics are discursively constructed and what implications they hold for decision-making communities.

Methods

This paper is an interpretive policy analysis of how supranational organisations conceptualise and strategically promote research engagement and evidence use in education policymaking. The approach draws on Yanow's (2000) interpretive framework, which emphasises the meanings, assumptions and discursive devices embedded in policy texts and is complemented by the conceptual framework presented earlier which draws upon prior related scholarship. This conceptual framework is not derived from a systematic review of the literature, but existing research that has helped refine the analytic lens and provide conceptual scaffolding for the interpretive analysis of supranational texts.

The interpretive policy analysis focuses on a curated set of six policy documents produced by the OECD, UNESCO and the World Bank between 2020 and 2025. Documents were identified through targeted searches of organisational portals using keywords such as "evidence," "knowledge mobilisation," and "policy." Inclusion criteria required that texts

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provide explicit guidance for policymakers and contain discursive features suitable for interpretive analysis, including metaphors, framing devices and normative claims. Texts lacking strategic relevance or discursive content were excluded. The final selection comprised policy papers, strategic reviews, terms of reference and advisory reports reflecting post-COVID reform priorities and alignment with Sustainable Development Goal 4. Table 1 presents the selected policy texts with inclusion rationales.

Approach to analysis

The interpretive analysis followed Yanow's (2000) framework (Figure 2) and related forms of policy analysis (Campbell, 2025), which involves identifying policy artifacts, mapping interpretive communities, analysing discursive constructions and locating sources of conflict and tension. Coding was conducted at the paragraph and section level, with attention to rhetorical devices, claims, implied mechanisms and systemic conditions. A linkage table mapped concepts derived from the literature to codes derived from the policy texts, ensuring analytic continuity across the conceptual and empirical components. Language, metaphors and exemplars within the texts were examined as carriers of meaning (Bandola-Gill *et al*., 2024; Burns, 2023), with particular attention to tensions between instrumental, symbolic and conceptual uses of evidence (Davies, 1999; Tseng, 2012) and divergences in epistemological assumptions and policy priorities (Sellar and Lingard, 2014; Wadhwa *et al*., 2024).

Table 1. Key texts

Policy text	Organisation	Title/Type	Summary of focus
OECD (2024)	OECD	*Yes Minister, Yes Evidence* – Policy Paper	Explores structures and skills for better evidence use in education policy; highlights systemic and organisational enablers
UNESCO IIEP (2025)	UNESCO	*Strategic Review*	Reviews global evidence use practices and proposes reforms to strengthen national and regional uptake
UNESCO IIEP (2025)	UNESCO IIEP Dakar	*Policy Brief #6*	Focuses on bridging research and policy in Sub-Saharan Africa; highlights local initiatives and barriers to evidence use
World Bank (2024)	World Bank, UK Aid, UNICEF, USAID	*GEEAP Terms of Reference*	Outlines the structure and purpose of the Global Education Evidence Advisory Panel; promotes cost-effective, evidence-based decision-making
OECD (2025)	OECD	*Everybody Cares About Using Education Research Sometimes* – Report	Synthesises findings from a global survey of 288 knowledge intermediaries; maps knowledge mobilisation activities, barriers, and systemic enablers; offers strategic guidance for improving evidence use in education policy and practice
World Bank (2024)	World Bank	Annual Report	Covers the Bank's activities from July 1, 2023 to June 30, 2024; highlights financial performance, regional and thematic results, strategic reforms, and future priorities. Focuses on climate action, digital transformation, knowledge and innovation, and operational reforms

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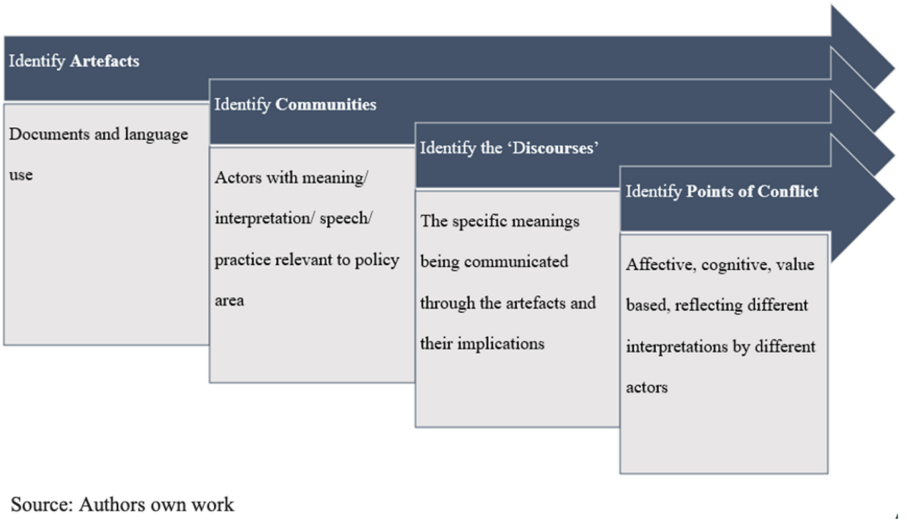


Figure 2. A framework for analysis (Adapted from Yanow (2000), Author (2025))

To support analytic depth and consistency, the study also drew on a general inductive approach (Thomas, 2006) and the framework method (Braun and Clarke, 2006; King and Horrocks, 2010). A five-stage process was followed: initial reading of texts, identification of keywords and themes, descriptive coding of selected segments, collation of codes into broader categories and interpretation of relationships across texts. A matrix-based framework was used to organise the data, drawing on Gale *et al*. (2013), with rows identifying data sources and columns capturing keyword usage, quotations and connections to the conceptual framework (Figure 1), the interpretive framework (Figure 2) and emerging themes. This methodical approach ensured transparency, rigour and credibility in the analysis (Smith and Firth, 2011; Ritchie and Lewis, 2003).

While interpretive policy analysis often relies solely on policy texts, this study acknowledges the complexity of policy implementation and the need for multiple analytical tools. As Dee *et al.* (2013) argue, given the multifaceted nature of policy and its enactment, a single lens is insufficient. The integration of concepts derived from the literature with interpretive analysis of supranational texts reflects a commitment to analytical depth and going beyond description to show how supranational discourses configure systemic conditions for evidence use.

Findings: Supranational Discourses of Research Engagement and Evidence Use

The interpretive analysis of the curated supranational policy texts reveals how organisations such as the OECD, UNESCO and the World Bank construct discourses around research engagement and evidence use. These texts frame evidence as both a strategic and symbolic resource, mobilising metaphors, rhetorical devices and normative claims to shape expectations and guide policy agendas. The findings are organised into six themes that illustrate the discursive strategies at play which are presented in Table 2.

Evidence as a strategic and relational construct

Evidence is consistently portrayed as a strategic and relational construct rather than a neutral input to decision-making. The OECD (2024, p. 2) stresses the need for

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Table 2. Supranational discourses

Policy text	Organisation	Discursive constructions	Key metaphors/ Language	Tensions/ Conflicts	Implications for decision-making communities
Yes Minister, Yes Evidence (OECD, 2024)	OECD	Evidence framed as a skillset and strategic asset	"Evidence journeys", "systems culture", "broken feedback loops"	Politicisation of evidence; lack of infrastructure	Need for internal capacity-building and feedback mechanisms
Strategic Review (UNESCO IIEP, 2025)	UNESCO	Evidence as relational and systemic	"Regional bridges", "knowledge equity", "bringing together two worlds"	Global dominance vs. local relevance	Emphasis on practitioner engagement and regional ownership
Policy Brief #6 (UNESCO IIEP, 2025)	UNESCO IIEP Dakar	Evidence as a tool for reform and local innovation	"Bridging research and policy", "local initiatives"	Fragmented ecosystems; limited coordination	Strengthening local networks and inclusive policy processes
GEEAP Terms of Reference (World Bank, 2024)	World Bank	Evidence as cost-effective and synthesised	"Smart buys", "decision-making under constraints"	Panel independence vs. convening agency influence	Importance of contextualisation and implementation guidance
Everybody Cares About Using Education Research Sometimes (OECD, 2025)	OECD	Evidence as a strategic guide for mobilisation	"Knowledge intermediaries", "mobilisation activities"	Disparities in uptake; symbolic vs. instrumental use	Need for tailored dissemination and intermediary support

Source(s): Authors' own work

structures that remain stable across political cycles while also enabling processes that feed research evidence systematically into decision making in all policy stages.

UNESCO echoes this emphasis on bridging research and practice, noting that "the process of bringing academic research and decision-making together therefore has to bridge the gap between theory and practice" (UNESCO IIEP, 2025, p. 3). These statements mark a departure from linear models of evidence use (Knott and Wildavsky, 1980), moving toward systems-oriented approaches that emphasise institutional arrangements and relational dynamics. The texts suggest that evidence is a relational product and process that requires infrastructures, cultures and governance arrangements to circulate purposefully across contexts. This framing positions evidence as embedded in political and institutional life, highlighting the importance of continuity across cycles and the relational work of connecting research and practice.

Metaphors and language as discursive tools

Language and metaphor emerge as powerful discursive tools in shaping how evidence is understood and valued. The OECD (2025, p. 25) describes knowledge mobilisation as a "jazz band," suggesting improvisation, collaboration and adaptive coordination among diverse actors. This metaphor contrasts sharply with Orland's (2009) metaphor of "separate orbits," which depicts research and policy as disconnected spheres. The World Bank (2024, p. 5) adds another rhetorical layer, stating:

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> We are refocusing to confront these challenges not just through funding, but with knowledge.

These metaphors and positioning go beyond illustration and signal underlying values and aspirations toward equity, collaboration and responsiveness, even if such commitments are not always realised in practice. They construct evidence cultures (Bandola-Gill *et al*., 2024) by embedding assumptions about how knowledge should be mobilised, who should lead and what forms of coordination are legitimate. The discursive framing of evidence therefore becomes inseparable from its strategic mobilisation, shaping legitimacy and uptake through the language in which it is embedded.

(Mis)alignments between global evidence narratives and local policy needs

The texts also reveal tensions between global evidence narratives and local policy needs. The World Bank's Global Education Evidence Advisory Panel (GEEAP) asserts:

> The panel is an independent body whose recommendations are based only on the evidence . . . not influenced by the interests of any governments, international organizations, or NGOs currently implementing policies or programs (World Bank, 2024, p. 2).

While this framing supports reliability, efficiency and scalability, it risks overlooking local relevance and contextual nuance. UNESCO IIEP (2025, p. 3) begins to acknowledges this gap, noting that

> there is often a gap between researchers and decision-makers in terms of communicating research findings.

While these focus more on instrumental dimensions of research and evidence use, these statements reflect broader critiques of epistemic dominance (Sellar and Lingard, 2014; Zhu *et al*., 2024), where global paradigms can marginalise local voices and priorities. The tension between global supply and local demand raises questions about epistemic autonomy and the extent to which national systems can assert their own knowledge traditions in the face of supranational frameworks.

Evidence use as capacity and competency

Evidence use is increasingly framed as a professional competency that individuals must learn, develop and apply. The OECD (2024, p. 2) states:

> Civil servants need a range of skills to engage with research . . . Policy makers also need to know where to access evidence, how to assess its quality, how to interpret findings and how to translate these for decision making.

UNESCO IIEP (2025, p. 3) reinforces this emphasis on national capacity-building, arguing that "countries have to be able to develop robust national research capacity in the area of education." While this competency framing aligns with Brown's (2014) call for phronetic expertise and Tseng's (2012) emphasis on interpretive judgement, it risks individualising responsibility and obscuring systemic constraints. Time pressures, limited access and institutional cultures that may not support inquiry all influence whether and how evidence is used. Without attending to these systemic factors, capacity-building efforts may not meet their aspirational goals and risk placing undue burden on individuals while neglecting the environmental or systemic factors that require consideration for sustained evidence use.

Epistemic inequality and representation

Questions of whose knowledge counts are central to how supranational discourses are mobilised and the influence they have UNESCO IIEP (2025, p. 3) suggests that "an effective combination of national skills development and use of international expertise could enrich the research framework." The OECD (2025, p. 166) envisions

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> the intermediary field to become an organic, self-developing ecosystem maintained and supported by adequate resources and incentive structures … towards a collective development of evidence syntheses with structured information about their quality and transferability across contexts.

These calls resonate with critiques of epistemic inequality and demands for pluralism (Zhu *et al.*, 2024; Cairney, 2016). They also highlight the need for participatory infrastructures that enable diverse actors such as researchers, practitioners and communities they are serving, to contribute meaningfully to evidence generation and use. Yet they also reveal the persistence of hierarchies, where global institutions continue to set the terms of inclusion and legitimacy.

Symbolic vs. instrumental use of evidence

Finally, the texts underscore the tension between symbolic and instrumental uses of evidence. UNESCO IIEP (2025, p. 2) observes:

> Education systems are often subjected to regular analyses that identify the same problems over the years … indicating that the initial recommendations have not been properly implemented.

The OECD (2024, p. 1) similarly notes:

> Policy makers and politicians often make anecdotal or fragmented use of research, using certain experiences and case-stories to underpin policies as needed. They may also use evidence selectively to confirm their own beliefs or support political agendas.

These insights highlight the performative dimensions of evidence use, where research is invoked to justify predetermined positions or to demonstrate alignment with international standards. Evidence becomes a tool of persuasion rather than a basis for deliberation, raising questions about the authenticity and efficacy of evidence-informed policymaking and the conditions under which evidence can genuinely shape decisions and reforms that lead to impact.

Discussion

The findings highlight the ways in which supranational organisations construct evidence as both a strategic and symbolic resource, embedding it within governance systems while simultaneously mobilising it rhetorically to signal reform intent. This duality reflects longstanding debates in the literature about the nature of evidence use in policymaking. Davies' (1999) typology of instrumental, symbolic and conceptual use remains highly relevant, as the analysis shows how evidence is invoked to legitimise decisions while also being promoted as iterative and relational. Lingard (2013) has argued that evidence functions as a political resource and the supranational texts examined here confirm that discursive devices are deployed to shape legitimacy and authority in ways that extend beyond technical rationality.

The metaphors and rhetorical framings identified in the OECD, UNESCO and World Bank documents illustrate how discursive constructions actively configure evidence cultures. Metaphors that were often mobilised in such texts not only illustrated intent and possibility, but also were constitutive of how knowledge is valued and mobilised (Bandola-Gill *et al*., 2024). The OECD's metaphor of the "jazz band" of knowledge mobilisation highlights a shift toward improvisational and collaborative coordination, contrasting with earlier depictions of research and policy as "separate orbits" (Orland, 2009). Burns (2023) highlights the importance of strategic framing in shaping usability and the findings here show that supranational organisations rely on language to embed assumptions about coordination, legitimacy and responsiveness. These discursive devices reveal that how evidence is spoken about matters as much as how it is used, reinforcing the argument that discourse is central to the politics of evidence and research use.

Tensions between global narratives and local needs emerge strongly in the texts, echoing critiques of epistemic dominance in the literature. The globalisation of evidence paradigms

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risks the marginalisation of local knowledge (Sellar and Lingard, 2014), and risks excluding indigenous and context-specific epistemologies (Zhu *et al.*, 2024). The World Bank's claim that its advisory panel is "independent" and "based only on the evidence" (World Bank, 2024, p. 2) reflects a technocratic logic that privileges universality, yet UNESCO IIEP (2025, p. 3) acknowledges the persistent gap between researchers and decision-makers. These tensions emphasise the need for pluralistic and context-sensitive approaches to evidence use (Pellegrini and Vivanet, 2021), and point to the limits of supranational framings that claim neutrality while shaping national agendas with varied engagement of different system actors.

The emphasis on capacity and competency in the texts resonates with related calls for the development and valuing of interpretive judgement, but it also risks individualising responsibility. By framing evidence use as a skillset civil servants must acquire, supranational organisations may obscure the systemic conditions that constrain engagement, such as time pressures, fragmented networks and misaligned incentives (Scanlon *et al.*, 2023; Gunn and Mintrom, 2021). Institutional capacity and organisational infrastructures play a significant role and the findings here suggest that authentic research engagement and evidence use requires supportive environments in addition to individual competencies (O'Connor, 2024; Lingard, 2013). This distinction between systemic capacity and individual competency is critical, as it highlights the relational and institutional dimensions of research and evidence use.

UNESCO IIEP's call for combining national skills with international expertise (2025, p. 3) and the OECD's vision of an "organic, self-developing ecosystem" (2025, p. 166) reflect aspirations toward inclusivity, yet they also reveal the difficulty of moving beyond entrenched hierarchies, and that epistemic inequality remains a persistent challenge. Zhu *et al.* (2024) argue that addressing epistemic inequality requires structural change, not just inclusion and Cairney (2016) reminds us that evidence is always politically mediated. The findings from this interpretive policy analysis confirm that supranational organisations continue to set the terms of legitimacy, even as they acknowledge the need for pluralism. Without structural reforms that redistribute epistemic authority, evidence risks being mobilised symbolically rather than substantively, reinforcing existing hierarchies rather than challenging them.

The symbolic mobilisation of evidence is arguably one of the most critically important themes identified. UNESCO's IIEP observation that systems repeatedly identify the same problems without implementing recommendations (2025, p. 2) and the OECD's note that policymakers often use anecdotal or fragmented evidence (2025, p. 1) highlight the performative dimensions of evidence use. This highlights the need for new, deliberative spaces where evidence can be engaged with critically and dialogically, and the findings here suggest that without such spaces, evidence will continue to be invoked rhetorically rather than substantively (Parkhurst, 2016; Nutley *et al.*, 2007). This raises important questions about authenticity and accountability in evidence-informed policymaking, and about the conditions under which evidence can genuinely shape decisions and reforms.

The findings from this analysis necessitate a revision of the initial conceptual framework proposed, and Figure 3 proposes a revised framework for conceptualising research and evidence use in education policy making. This framework integrates the five initial domains, conceptions of evidence, actors and networks, processes of use, mechanisms of integration and systemic conditions, while explicitly incorporating discursive devices, tensions and the distinction between symbolic and instrumental uses. It emphasises how discursive constructions are central, recognising that metaphors, narratives and rhetorical framings actively shape evidence cultures. The framework also introduces three further elements: participatory approaches, which highlight the importance of inclusive and co-constructed processes of research engagement and evidence use; relational models, which emphasise the interpersonal and networked dimensions of research and evidence use; and system learning and feedback loops, which capture the iterative cycles through which evidence informs policy and policy generates new evidence and research needs. These elements are continually influenced by broader contextual dimensions such as global–local dynamics, which shape how

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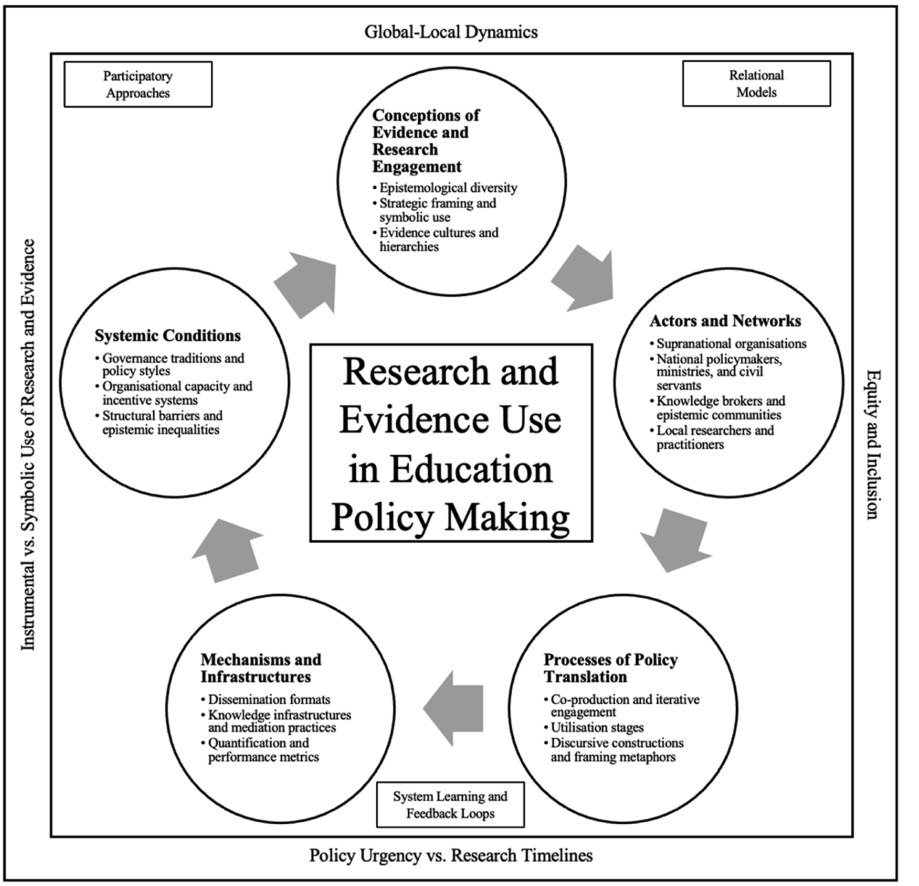


Figure 3. A framework for conceptualising research and evidence use in education policy making

knowledge travels and is adapted across scales; equity and inclusion, which determine whose voices and epistemologies are legitimised; policy urgency versus research timelines, which create tensions between rapid decision-making and the slower pace of knowledge production; and the persistent challenge of instrumental versus symbolic use of research and evidence, which affects whether evidence is engaged with authentically or rhetorically. By embedding these considerations, the revised framework distinguishes between systemic capacity and individual competency, emphasises the need for enabling environments alongside professional skills and places epistemic justice at the heart of research and evidence use, highlighting the importance of inclusive knowledge systems and deliberative spaces where diverse epistemologies can contribute meaningfully.

By embedding these additional considerations, the revised framework enables a means to theorise how supranational discourses configure the systemic conditions under which evidence is mobilised and research is engaged with. It highlights that evidence-informed policymaking requires technical capacity and methodological rigour, but also contested, discursively mediated process shaped by power, representation and legitimacy. For decision-making communities that may comprise policy teams, school leaders and professional networks, this would require navigating both the structural enablers and the rhetorical

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framings that define what counts as valid evidence and how it is expected to be used. Authentic and meaningful research and evidence use requires the skills, infrastructures, spaces for deliberation, reflexivity and contestation, together offering the literal and figurative spaces where research and evidence can be engaged with critically and oriented toward meaningful change.

Conclusions

Supranational organisations shape education policy by framing research and evidence as socially constructed, strategically mobilised resources rather than neutral inputs, thereby influencing what counts as valid knowledge and how it is used in practice (Lingard, 2013; Cairney, 2016). Bodies such as the OECD, UNESCO and the World Bank promote evidence-informed policymaking that often privileges quantitative, comparative and synthesis-based methods, while marginalising practice-based, indigenous and locally grounded knowledges (Sellar and Lingard, 2014; Pellegrini and Vivanet, 2021; Wadhwa *et al*., 2024). These framings are enacted through networks, intermediaries and platforms, such as epistemic communities, clearinghouses and brokerage organisations, that curate, translate and disseminate evidence, shaping standards, incentives and infrastructures for uptake (Ball and Junemann, 2012; Baek and Steiner;Khamsi, 2024). As a result, evidence use is mediated by systemic conditions including governance traditions, capacity, time pressures and incentive structures, that determine whether research is applied instrumentally, invoked symbolically, or absorbed conceptually (Davies, 1999; Scanlon *et al*., 2023). Tensions between global universals and local relevance produce epistemic inequalities that risk performative policymaking unless efforts prioritise inclusive co-production, context sensitivity and sustained capacity and brokerage to enable authentic, accountable and equitable evidence use and research engagement (Zhu *et al*., 2024; Brown, 2014).

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